

Something Went Wrong

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The message is offered with a kind of studied humility, as though the system were as puzzled by the failure as you are, two parties equally in the dark, bonded briefly by mutual confusion. This is almost never true. Somewhere behind the message sits a stack trace naming the exact function that failed, the exact input that broke it, often the exact line number, logged automatically, timestamped, and routed to a dashboard that someone on staff will glance at before lunch. The system knows precisely what went wrong. It has simply decided, or had decided for it, that telling you would cost more than it's worth.

What it would cost is specificity, and specificity is dangerous, because a specific error can be argued with. "The payment failed because the card issuer declined the transaction" invites a follow-up question aimed at the card issuer, or a support call, or a screenshot forwarded to someone whose job is to explain the decline. "Something went wrong" invites nothing, because it names nothing, and an error with no proper noun in it cannot be escalated to anyone in particular. The vagueness is not a limitation of the diagnostic system. It is very often the output of a perfectly good diagnostic system, laundered on the way to the screen into a sentence engineered to be un-actionable, the customer-service equivalent of a shrug performed by an entity that does not have shoulders.

Refresh the page and try again, it suggests, which is advice indistinguishable from doing nothing, dressed as a next step so the interaction has the shape of a resolution without the content of one. The apology is real. The ignorance is not. And the gap between those two things is where an entire category of software support has learned to live comfortably, indefinitely, without ever being asked to close it.